

Module 4 — The Social Filter

Module purpose

Socialisation is not about exposing the dog to everything as fast as possible.

It is about helping the dog learn that normal life can be safe, calm, and manageable.

This module helps the owner introduce people, places, sounds, surfaces, handling, and everyday experiences without forcing the dog past their coping point.

This is not advanced fear treatment.

This is safe exposure, better observation, and knowing when to stop or seek support.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 4, the owner should be able to:

1. Understand that socialisation means safe, positive exposure, not forced interaction.
 2. Recognise when the dog is coping, unsure, or overwhelmed.
 3. Use distance and choice when the dog is worried.
 4. Avoid flooding the dog with scary experiences.
 5. Plan low-risk early exposure while following veterinary advice.
 6. Help the dog experience common sights, sounds, surfaces, people, and handling safely.
 7. Know when fear is outside self-guided education.
 8. Record useful exposure and fear notes for a vet or trainer.
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Lesson 1 — Socialisation Is Not Forced Interaction

Scenario

You take your puppy or new dog to meet friends.

Everyone is excited. People lean over the dog, reach toward the head, talk loudly, and encourage the dog to “say hello.”

The dog backs away, hides behind you, freezes, licks their lips, or refuses treats.

Someone says:

“They need to get used to it.”

What the owner needs to notice

Socialisation is not the same as contact.

A dog can learn from:

- watching people from a distance
- hearing household sounds
- walking on different surfaces
- seeing bikes, prams, hats, uniforms, umbrellas, or delivery drivers
- gently exploring new objects
- being near calm dogs without meeting them
- hearing traffic from a safe distance
- short relaxed handling sessions

The dog does not need to be touched by every person or meet every dog.

The goal is a positive or neutral experience.

Common mistake

Forcing the dog toward the thing they are scared of.

Examples:

- dragging the dog closer
- holding the dog still while people pat them
- passing the dog around
- making the dog "face their fear"
- letting strangers crowd the dog
- taking the dog into busy dog parks before they are ready
- treating fear as stubbornness

This can make the dog more worried next time.

Better decision rule

Exposure only counts if the dog is coping.

Ask:

Is my dog able to observe, recover, and stay relaxed enough to learn?

If the answer is no, increase distance or end the session.

What to do now

Use safe observation.

Choose one small exposure:

- one person at a distance
- one new surface
- one quiet sound
- one calm object
- one short car experience
- one gentle handling moment
- one quiet location

Keep it short.

Let the dog decide whether to approach.

Reward calm observation with food, praise, play, or distance, depending on what the dog finds rewarding.

End while the dog is still coping.

Watch for this

The dog is probably coping if they can:

- eat
- sniff
- move normally
- look away and recover
- approach and retreat
- show soft body movement
- choose to re-engage
- settle afterward

The dog may not be coping if they:

- freeze
- hide
- pull away
- refuse food
- tremble
- pant when not hot
- bark repeatedly
- growl
- snap
- try to escape
- cannot recover after distance increases

When education is not enough

Seek professional support if:

- fear is intense
- fear is escalating
- the dog freezes, growls, snaps, or bites
- the dog cannot recover after the trigger is removed
- the dog panics around normal daily experiences
- children, visitors, or other animals are involved and safety is uncertain
- the owner feels unsure how to manage exposure safely

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Record:

- what the dog saw, heard, touched, or experienced
 - distance from the trigger
 - first sign of worry
 - whether the dog could take food
 - whether the dog could move away
 - how long recovery took
 - what helped
 - what made it worse
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Lesson 2 — Safe Early Exposure Before the World Gets Too Big

Scenario

Your puppy is not fully vaccinated yet.

You have read that early socialisation matters, but you are worried about disease risk. You are unsure whether the puppy should stay inside, go outside, attend puppy school, meet vaccinated dogs, or be carried around.

What the owner needs to notice

This is a balance question.

Puppies need early, positive experiences, but disease risk still matters.

The owner should not make this decision from internet advice alone. Local risk, vaccination status, puppy health, and the environment matter.

The first step is to ask the vet:

What is safe exposure for this puppy in our local area right now?

Common mistake

Choosing one extreme.

Extreme 1:

“Keep the puppy completely isolated until every vaccine is finished.”

Extreme 2:

“Take the puppy everywhere and let them meet every dog.”

Both can create problems.

The safer middle is planned, low-risk exposure guided by veterinary advice.

Better decision rule

Separate exposure from risky contact.

Ask:

Can my puppy safely experience the world without direct contact with unknown dogs or contaminated areas?

Often, the answer is yes.

What to do now

Discuss local risk with the vet.

Then use low-risk exposure options that fit the vet's advice.

Possible options include:

- carrying the puppy while they watch people, traffic, bikes, uniforms, prams, and everyday movement
- sitting in the car with the puppy while they calmly watch the world
- inviting calm visitors to stand at a distance
- introducing household objects at home
- playing low-volume everyday sounds at home
- creating a surface walk in the yard or home
- attending a reputable indoor puppy class if appropriate
- arranging exposure to healthy, vaccinated, well-mannered dogs in safe private settings if vet-approved

Avoid high-risk choices until the vet says they are suitable.

These may include:

- dog parks
- busy off-leash areas
- places heavily used by unknown dogs
- contact with sick or unvaccinated dogs
- uncontrolled puppy play
- crowded pet events

Watch for this

The exposure is too much if the puppy:

- stops eating
- tries to hide
- trembles
- freezes
- becomes frantic
- cannot disengage
- cannot recover afterward
- becomes more worried each time

The exposure is more appropriate if the puppy:

- notices and recovers
- takes food
- explores calmly
- can retreat
- remains playful or relaxed
- settles afterward

When education is not enough

Seek vet advice if:

- the puppy is unwell
- vaccination or disease risk is unclear
- the puppy has had contact with sick or unknown dogs
- the owner is unsure about puppy class safety
- local outbreak risk may be relevant

Seek trainer or behaviour support if:

- the puppy repeatedly panics during low-intensity exposure
- fear is increasing
- the puppy cannot recover
- the puppy growls, snaps, or attempts to flee

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Ask the vet:

- What areas should we avoid until vaccination is complete?
- Is puppy school appropriate now?
- What exposure is safe before full vaccination?
- Can the puppy meet known vaccinated dogs?
- What symptoms after an outing should make us call?

Tell a trainer:

- what exposure has been tried
 - what distance the puppy can handle
 - what triggers fear
 - whether food is accepted
 - how long recovery takes
 - what the vet has advised about disease risk
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Lesson 3 — The Traffic-Light Rule for Fear

Scenario

Your dog sees something unfamiliar: a skateboard, child, high-vis worker, umbrella, vacuum, grooming brush, car, statue, or person wearing a hat.

Sometimes the dog looks curious.

Sometimes they hesitate.

Sometimes they bark, hide, or panic.

You are unsure whether to continue or stop.

What the owner needs to notice

The same experience can be safe or unsafe depending on the dog's emotional state.

Use a traffic-light filter.

Green

The dog is coping.

They may:

- look calmly
- eat
- sniff

- approach and retreat
- move normally
- show loose body movement
- recover quickly

Green means:

Continue gently or end on a good note.

Yellow

The dog is unsure.

They may:

- pause
- lean away
- lower their body
- lick lips
- yawn
- move behind the owner
- hesitate before taking food
- need more distance

Yellow means:

Make it easier.

Red

The dog is overwhelmed.

They may:

- freeze
- refuse food
- tremble
- bark repeatedly
- growl
- snap
- try to escape
- hide
- panic
- fail to recover

Red means:

Stop the exposure and create safety.

Common mistake

Turning yellow into red.

This happens when the owner thinks:

“They are almost doing it. I’ll just push a little more.”

But if the dog is already unsure, pushing can turn a manageable experience into a fear memory.

Better decision rule

Stay in green. Respect yellow. Exit red.

Ask:

Is this still easy enough for my dog?

If not, step back.

What to do now

Use the traffic-light response.

If green

- reward calm observation
- keep the session short
- finish while the dog is coping

If yellow

- increase distance
- lower intensity
- reduce movement or noise
- allow retreat
- reward recovery
- end soon

If red

- stop
- move away
- do not punish
- do not keep exposing
- allow recovery
- record what happened
- seek help if repeated or unsafe

Watch for this

A good exposure session usually ends quietly.

Afterward, the dog should be able to:

- settle
- eat
- sleep
- move normally
- return to regular behaviour

If the dog remains unsettled for a long time, the session was too hard.

When education is not enough

Seek support if the dog:

- regularly goes straight to red
- has repeated red reactions to normal life
- cannot recover after distance
- is becoming more fearful over time
- shows growling, snapping, lunging, or biting
- is unsafe around children, visitors, dogs, or public spaces

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Track the dog's traffic-light level for each exposure.

Record:

- exposure type
- distance
- dog's colour: green, yellow, or red
- first body signal
- food accepted: yes/no
- recovery time
- what helped
- what to avoid next time

Lesson 4 — Handling, Grooming, and Vet Touch

Scenario

You try to touch your dog's paws, ears, mouth, tail, collar, or harness.

The dog pulls away, mouths your hand, stiffens, hides, growls, or becomes frantic.

You worry this will make grooming and vet visits difficult.

What the owner needs to notice

Handling is an experience the dog learns.

The dog needs to learn that gentle touch predicts safety, choice, and reward.

This matters for:

- vet checks
- grooming
- nail care
- ear checks
- mouth checks
- harness fitting
- collar handling
- medication if ever needed
- emergency handling

Handling should not begin with restraint and conflict.

Common mistake

Doing too much too quickly.

Examples:

- grabbing paws suddenly
- forcing nail trims
- holding the dog still while they struggle
- touching sensitive areas for too long
- ignoring stiffening, head turns, mouthing, or growling
- waiting until grooming or vet care is urgent before practising

Better decision rule

Touch should stay easy enough that the dog can recover.

Ask:

Can my dog accept this touch calmly, or do I need to make it smaller?

If the dog pulls away, stiffens, or panics, the step is too big.

What to do now

Practise micro-handling.

Keep sessions very short.

Start with one easy body area.

Example:

1. Touch shoulder briefly.
2. Reward.
3. Stop.
4. Repeat later.

Then slowly build toward more sensitive areas.

Possible sequence:

- shoulder
- chest
- side
- collar area
- leg
- paw
- ear
- mouth area
- tail

Do not force the full sequence in one session.

Use calm rewards.

Stop before the dog becomes worried.

Watch for this

Handling is too hard if the dog:

- turns away
- stiffens
- licks lips
- mouths hands
- pulls the body part away
- hides
- growls
- snaps
- stops taking food
- becomes frantic

Handling is more appropriate if the dog:

- stays loose
- can take food
- can move away
- re-engages willingly

- settles afterward

When education is not enough

Seek vet advice if:

- handling discomfort is sudden
- one body part seems painful
- the dog yelps, guards, limps, scratches, shakes the head, or avoids touch on one side
- there is swelling, discharge, bleeding, skin change, ear smell, dental concern, or injury

Seek trainer or behaviour support if:

- the dog panics during normal handling
- grooming or vet visits are unsafe
- the dog growls, snaps, or bites during handling
- the owner cannot complete basic care safely

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet or trainer:

- which body areas cause concern
 - what the dog does first
 - whether the reaction is sudden or long-standing
 - whether pain signs are present
 - what handling is necessary now
 - what has already been tried
 - whether the dog can take food during handling
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Tool 1 — Safe Exposure Checklist

Use this before each new exposure.

Before exposure

- ☐ Vet guidance has been considered if vaccination or disease risk is relevant
- ☐ Exposure is short
- ☐ Dog can move away
- ☐ Reward is ready
- ☐ Owner knows how to create distance
- ☐ No forced contact
- ☐ No crowded dog areas if not appropriate
- ☐ No unknown dogs if risk is unclear
- ☐ Session can end early

During exposure

- ☐ Dog can eat
- ☐ Dog can sniff
- ☐ Dog can look away
- ☐ Dog can retreat
- ☐ Dog is not frozen
- ☐ Dog is not panicking
- ☐ Dog is not being crowded
- ☐ Owner is watching body language

After exposure

- ☐ Dog recovered quickly
- ☐ Dog settled afterward
- ☐ No prolonged fear response
- ☐ Trigger and distance were recorded
- ☐ Next session will be easier if needed

Tool 2 — Traffic-Light Exposure Log

Date	Exposure	Distance/ intensity	Green/ yellow/ red	First worry sign	Food accepted?	Recovery time	Next adjustment
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How to use the log

After three entries, ask:

- Which triggers are green?
- Which triggers are yellow?
- Which triggers are red?
- Is fear improving, unchanged, or worsening?
- Does distance help?
- Does the dog recover quickly?
- Is professional support needed?

Tool 3 — Safe Handling Practice Card

Use this for paws, ears, mouth, collar, harness, grooming, and vet preparation.

Practice rule

Short, easy, rewarded, and stopped before worry appears.

Session plan

- ☐ Choose one body area
- ☐ Touch briefly
- ☐ Reward
- ☐ Stop
- ☐ Repeat later
- ☐ Do not force
- ☐ Do not restrain through panic
- ☐ Do not continue after growling, snapping, or freezing

Track

Body area	Dog response	Food accepted?	Recovery	Next step
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Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 4 when they can confirm:

- ☐ They understand socialisation is safe exposure, not forced contact
 - ☐ They can identify green, yellow, and red responses
 - ☐ They can create distance when the dog is unsure
 - ☐ They know not to flood the dog
 - ☐ They know to ask the vet about local vaccination and exposure safety
 - ☐ They have tried at least one safe exposure session
 - ☐ They have started gentle handling practice
 - ☐ They know when fear requires vet or trainer support
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Module 4 dashboard summary

Current focus

Help the dog experience the world without pushing past their coping point.

Today's action

Choose one small exposure and record whether the dog was green, yellow, or red.

Capability gained

Fear response and safe exposure.

Decision rule

Exposure only helps if the dog is coping.

Escalation reminder

Repeated panic, freezing, growling, snapping, biting, inability to recover, or sudden handling sensitivity needs professional support.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- trigger
 - distance
 - first worry sign
 - traffic-light level
 - whether the dog could eat
 - whether the dog could move away
 - recovery time
 - what helped
 - what made it worse
 - what the vet advised about vaccination or health concerns
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Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 4 is supported primarily by:

- Australian Veterinary Association policy on puppy and kitten socialisation and habituation. AVA defines socialisation and habituation, states that positive early life experiences prepare puppies for companion life, warns that inadequate socialisation can contribute to fear and problematic behaviour, and says puppies should not be forced into interactions because this can worsen fear during sensitive periods.
- AVA guidance that the puppy sensitive period starts around three weeks and wanes around fourteen weeks, while also noting dogs continue learning beyond this period. AVA also states that socialisation occurs before full vaccination and that benefits can outweigh disease risks when precautions are taken.
- AVA guidance for new owners that, prior to full vaccination, appropriate options can include indoor puppy classes with similarly isolated individuals and healthy fully vaccinated pets in private residences, with disease-risk balance discussed with the veterinarian.
- AVA guidance that learning sessions should be short, supervised, positively reinforced, and allow puppies to choose not to approach or to withdraw if fearful or anxious.

- RSPCA Knowledgebase guidance that puppies not fully vaccinated can still be exposed to the world by being carried, and that new sights, objects, surfaces, sounds, handling, car experiences, and alone-time practice can be introduced at home with positive rewards and low intensity.
- AVSAB puppy socialisation statement as Tier 2 support. AVSAB states that the first three months are the primary socialisation period, that puppies should receive safe socialisation before full vaccination, that puppy classes can begin early with vaccine and parasite precautions, and that dog parks or highly trafficked unsanitised areas should be avoided.
- AVSAB humane dog training statement as Tier 2 support for avoiding force, fear, intimidation, pain, aversive tools, and flooding, and for using reward-based methods and safe opt-out learning.
- Earlier Gemini rough scan: retained only as an idea pool and not used as primary curriculum evidence because it included weak or non-preferred sources.

Claims requiring careful wording

Socialisation

Approved wording:

Socialisation means safe, positive exposure to people, animals, environments, sounds, objects, surfaces, and experiences.

Avoid:

Socialisation means meeting every person and dog.

Vaccination and early exposure

Approved wording:

Ask your vet how to balance vaccination safety with safe early exposure in your local area.

Avoid:

Take every puppy everywhere before vaccination is complete.

Fear response

Approved wording:

If the dog is scared, increase distance, reduce pressure, and allow retreat.

Avoid:

Force the dog to face the fear.

Puppy classes

Approved wording:

A reputable indoor puppy class may be appropriate when vaccination, hygiene, and local disease-risk precautions are discussed with a vet.

Avoid:

All puppies should attend any puppy class immediately.

Handling

Approved wording:

Practise gentle, short, rewarded handling and stop before the dog becomes worried.

Avoid:

Hold the dog still until they accept it.

Escalation

Approved wording:

Seek vet or trainer support when fear is intense, repeated, escalating, unsafe, linked to handling pain, or the dog cannot recover.

Avoid:

This module treats serious fear, aggression, or trauma.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```
```text id="y4fwrh" /docs/education/curriculum/04-the-social-filter.md
```

Optional supporting files:

```
```text id="fkxpi8"  
/docs/education/tools/safe-exposure-checklist.md  
/docs/education/tools/traffic-light-exposure-log.md  
/docs/education/tools/safe-handling-practice-card.md  
/docs/education/research/module-4-the-social-filter-source-map.md
```